

their thoughts and opinions with community-driven moderation of the content that is being posted on the platform.

Not a day goes by when we do not see Elon Musk making headlines about some change or another to the platform. While it is truly up for debate how effective his moves to make X a safe haven for the folks willing to put their opinion out on the internet, one thing can be said for sure – He is leading the charge. Ever since he assumed the leadership of X, Musk has been vocal about all things on his platform. Be it politics, finance, or his own position in the context of building a platform where everyone is free to express what they want, Musk has been vocal.

The signs of Musk's charge for change were visible from the time he had announced his bid to acquire Twitter. "By 'free speech', I simply mean that which matches the law. I am against censorship that goes far beyond the law. If people want less free speech, they will ask the government to pass laws to that effect. Therefore, going beyond the law is contrary to the will of the people", said Elon in a Tweet right after the Twitter Board had accepted his offer to acquire Twitter for \$44 billion. Since then, Musk has made multiple changes, spanning the lengths and breadths of X's organisational structure to reflect his vision on the platform. We have seen accounts re-instated, and opinions which would not have flown on the older version of the platform get free reign.

Giving control in the hands of the community to ensure the sanctity of X, 'Community Notes' were added as a feature which enabled the community to add relevant contextual information to posts on the platform which are meant to misdirect or spread misinformation on the platform. X itself has taken active measures to ensure that the platform does not become a ranch where bad

actors are grazing on the grass of the innocent folk using the platform.

A significant move that stood out during our research on the topic was when X announced that the platform would limit the reach of the posts, which violated the platform's policies. In their blog post titled, Freedom of Speech, Not Reach: An update on our enforcement philosophy, X's Safety team wrote, "Our mission at Twitter 2.0 is to promote and protect the public conversation. We believe Twitter users have the right to express their opinions and ideas without fear of censorship. We also believe it is our responsibility to keep users on our platform safe from content violating our Rules. These beliefs are the foundation of Freedom of Speech, not Freedom of Reach - our enforcement philosophy, which means, where appropriate, restricting the reach of Tweets that violate our policies by making the content less discoverable."

Again, we can debate for ages whether Musk's moves are right or wrong. However, we need to focus on what is happening on the platform and, given its increased popularity, whether the changes reflect positively or negatively on the life of a regular *Xrati*.

PRIVATISATION OF TWITTER TO X

In his bid to promote "free speech" on the platform, one of the biggest moves Musk made right after the acquisition was to take the company private. Twitter was officially delisted from the New York Stock Exchange in November 2022. Here, I would like to quote our very own Mithun Mohandas, who opined on this matter in the May 2022 issue of Digit in his article titled, "twitter's (mostly) going to be the same" –

"A good chunk of the arguments being made revolve around accountability and the fact that being a publicly traded company immediately makes the company accountable to the people because they own the company and the stockholders and company officials are bound by their fiduciary duties to serve the people. Yes, fiduciary duty is legality that prevents the board of any company to run amok and indulge their own silly whims. It makes them accountable and responsible to answer the stockholders. But has anyone actually looked at Twitter's stock ownership?

As of writing this, 40.95 per cent of Twitter stock is owned by



Mutual Fund holders, 35.92 per cent is owned by other Institutional holders and Individual stakeholders only form 12.48 per cent of the total. And who owned Twitter before Elon Musk came along with his monies? Well, over 80 per cent of Twitter stock was held by private firms and investment funds in early March 2022. So was Twitter truly bound to be accountable to the people? Nope. And the fact is that nothing much has changed. Instead of a lot more investors, we now have fewer investors. The general public never really had much of a say before and they'll not have much of a say now either."

There is not much to add here. We are seeing the implications of the move unfold in front of us every